

Food Court Tycoon

Characters & Venues, From Scratch

A full replacement of the customer/staff figures and the seven venue backdrops — same programmatic-SwiftUI pipeline, a materially better result.

SCOPE	Characters + venue backgrounds only
CONSTRAINT	100% vector SwiftUI — zero bundled images
VENUES	7, each a distinct room and mood
STATUS	Supersedes the Aug 2026 visual-refresh pass

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1. The Mandate

Owner verdict: **“the venue and character art needs sprucing up.”** The prior visual-refresh pass (docs/design-brief.md, shipped Aug 2026) added gradients, glow, and lighting layers on top of the existing character and backdrop shapes. That was the right call at the time — it fixed “flat and lifeless.” It did not fix “the shapes themselves are simple.” The customer figure is still four rounded rectangles and two circles; the venue backdrop is still a gradient wall with a handful of small prop icons pinned to it. This brief asks for the opposite move: throw out the current character silhouette and the current backdrop composition, and design new ones from a blank page.

What “from scratch” means here: the seeded-variation system (one integer seed → a whole crowd that reads as varied, not cloned) and the per-venue palette identity are worth keeping — they're proven, tested, and load-bearing elsewhere in the app (see §6). Keep those two ideas. Replace everything about how a body, a face, an outfit, a wall, and a floor are actually drawn.

2. Scope: What This Brief Covers (and Doesn't)

In scope:

- The customer/staff figure and its variation system (CustomerSprite.swift): body, face, hair, outfits, the hat, and how a seed turns those into a crowd.
- The manager rarity portrait frame (ManagerRarityFrame) that surrounds staff portraits in the Collection sheet and hire flows.
- The Golden Customer / VIP critic presentation (the special jackpot encounter).
- All seven venue backdrops: wall, floor, counter, hanging sign, prop dressing, and the lighting/depth treatment that ties them together (VenueProps.swift, VenueStageView.swift).

Explicitly out of scope — do not touch, do not let the redesign's logic bleed into these:

- Food/station icons (FoodSprite.swift) — fries, burgers, sushi rolls, etc. Recently reworked, not part of this complaint.
- HUD glyphs, tab bar icons, coin/gem iconography (Icons.swift) — separate bespoke-glyph pass already shipped and is not what “needs sprucing up” refers to.
- Payout/confetti/coin-burst effects (CoinBurst.swift) — juice layer, not character or venue art.
- Any gameplay, balance, or layout code. This is a pure art-asset brief.

If the new character or venue style implies a food-icon or HUD-icon refresh would look better alongside it, note that as a *follow-up recommendation* at the end of the work rather than doing it inline — keep this pass reviewable as one coherent unit.

3. The One Hard Constraint

Every piece of art in this game is programmatic SwiftUI vector code. There are no bundled image assets — no PNGs, no SVG files loaded at runtime, no asset catalog entries beyond the app icon. That does not change. A character is a Swift function that draws paths, fills, and strokes into a Canvas; a venue backdrop is the same. This is not a legacy constraint to work around — it's *why* the seeded-variation system exists at all (a hand-drawn PNG can't be recolored and reportioned per-seed at zero asset cost; a vector function can), and it's why the whole game is a ~40KB binary with no art pipeline, no texture atlas, no cache-miss pop-in, and no App Store size bloat as venues and rarity tiers multiply.

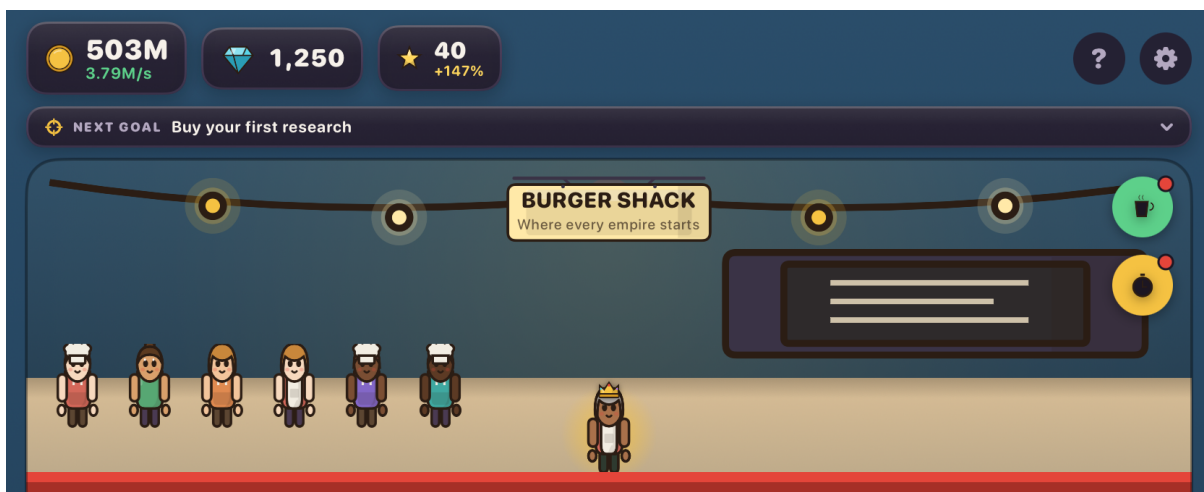
Practically, this means the redesign has to be expressible as:

- 1 Bezier paths, ellipses, and rounded rects composed in a SwiftUI Canvas (see the existing `p()` / `custom()` / `fill()` helper pattern in `CustomerSprite.swift` — reuse or improve this pattern, don't invent a parallel one).
- 2 Gradients and radial glows via SwiftUI's native `LinearGradient`/`RadialGradient`, exactly as `VenueStageView.swift` already does for the wall wash and vignette.
- 3 Parametrized by a small palette (5–8 hex colors per venue, or per seeded roll for a character) so recoloring for a new venue or a cosmetic skin is a data change, not new drawing code.

A design partner more comfortable in Figma/Illustrator than Swift should still design this visually first — but every shape needs to be simple enough (bezier curves, not 500-point traced outlines) that it translates to hand-written `Path` code without needing an SVG import pipeline the project doesn't have.

4. Current State — What's Actually Live Today

The screenshot below is the actual current build (iPad, built-out Burger Shack board, captured this session) — not a mockup, not an old build. This is the thing being replaced.



Current live build: Burger Shack backdrop, six staff figures at the counter, one Golden Customer (crowned, center-stage).

Character diagnosis:

- Silhouette is a torso rounded-rect, two leg rounded-rects, and a circle head — no neck, no shoulder width variation, no hands (tools/trays aren't held, they float or are implied). Reads instantly as a placeholder figure rather than a character.
- All six queued figures share one pose and one scale. Variation is limited to skin/hair/shirt/pants color plus 3 hairstyles × 3 outfit cuts × a 1-in-4 hat chance — real, but shallow enough that a full counter of six reads as “six recolors,” not six people.
- Zero idle motion. Managers assigned to a station and customers in the queue are completely static; only the CoinBurst/serve-event layer animates.
- The Golden Customer is the same rig with a crown added — a jackpot moment that should feel special looks like a manager with a hat.

Venue backdrop diagnosis:

- Structurally the same room, seven times: gradient wall → radial light pool → small pinned prop icons → gradient floor → counter band → hanging sign. The only thing that changes between Burger Shack and the Midnight Diner is the hex values and which 3–4 prop glyphs get pinned to the wall.
- “Props” are small isolated icons (a grill, a shelf, a menu board) floating on an otherwise empty wall — there's no sense of a built room: no floor-to-wall furniture, no depth beyond one radial gradient, no signage/texture that make Sushi Bar feel like a different physical place than Taco Fiesta beyond the color swap.
- No ambient life: no steam, no motion, no time-of-day variation, nothing drawing the eye around the space independent of the customer queue.
- Counter/floor meet at a single hard gradient seam — reads as two flat planes glued together, not a continuous room.

5. Character System — Rebuild Spec

5.1 Direction

Move to a proportioned, stylized figure with a genuine silhouette — the big-head-to-body ratio, rounded/soft shapes, and high color saturation common to the top-grossing casual/idle-tycoon genre (think character-select screens in mobile tycoon and cooking games broadly, not any one title specifically — the brief is a genre convention, not a reference to copy). The goal is a figure that reads clearly at 48–64pt (a station-card staff badge) *and* holds up at 140–200pt (a Collection-sheet portrait or the center-stage Golden Customer), using the same base rig scaled up with more line detail rendered in at the larger size if needed.

5.2 Anatomy the current rig is missing

- A neck/shoulder transition — head should not sit flush on a rectangular torso.
- Arms with a visible bend and hands — at minimum, one hand should be able to hold a prop (spatula, tray, cup) for staff figures, since "what job does this person do" is currently unreadable from the figure alone.
- A wider shoulder-to-hip taper so the torso reads as a body, not a rounded box.
- A simple 2–3 point face (eyes + a mouth curve at minimum) — the current figure appears to have no face at all in the queue view; personality has to come from somewhere other than shirt color.

5.3 Variation system — keep the mechanism, deepen the inputs

The seeded approach (one Int seed deterministically drives every choice via SeededRandom) is correct and should not change — it's what lets the same customer look the same every time they're drawn without persisting anything, and what makes a six-person queue actually vary without art-team effort per instance. What should grow is the *number of independent slots* the seed drives, so six people at a counter stop reading as six palette swaps of one template:

- Current: skin, hair color, shirt color, pants color, 1-of-3 hairstyle, 1-of-3 outfit, 1-in-4 hat.
- Add: body build/height variation (2–3 proportions, not just color), a face variant (2–3 expressions or feature sets), and an accessory slot independent of the hat (glasses, apron, name tag) so "no hat" isn't the default 3-in-4 case reading as the same person.
- Keep the venue-themed outfit hook: today a manager's outfit is generic; consider whether the rebuilt outfit set can carry a light per-venue tint or accessory (an apron color matching the venue accent, e.g.) so a Sushi Bar crowd and a Taco Fiesta crowd feel placed in their room, not interchangeable between venues.

5.4 Rarity portrait frame

The manager rarity ring (ManagerRarityFrame) recolors per tier but is otherwise one static ring shape today. Redesign as a frame family that escalates in complexity, not just color — the whole point of a rarity system is that Legendary should be unmistakable across a room at a glance:

Rarity	Ring / accent color	Frame idea
Common	#B3A8C0 (muted lavender-grey)	Plain ring, no ornament
Rare	Theme.gem (cyan)	Ring gains a faceted inner bevel

Rarity	Ring / accent color	Frame idea
Epic	#B07BE8 (violet)	Ring gains a soft outer glow
Legendary	Theme.star (gold)	Ring animates -- see §5.4

“Animates” for Legendary means something cheap and static-fallback-able: a slow hue-shift shimmer or a rotating highlight along the ring, gated behind `accessibilityReduceMotion` exactly like every other ambient animation in this codebase (see §8).

6. Venue Backgrounds — Rebuild Spec

6.1 Direction

Each of the seven venues should read as a specific, furnished room with its own storytelling detail — not a recolored template with different icons pinned to it. The brief is for a genuine scene: back wall with real depth (not one flat gradient plane), furniture and equipment appropriate to that food type built into the wall rather than floating on it, and enough per-venue specificity that a screenshot of the backdrop alone (no sign, no HUD) identifies which of the seven venues it is.

6.2 Depth — the room needs layers

Current structure is two flat planes (wall, floor) plus a radial light wash. Rebuild as a true layered scene, back to front:

- 1 **Back wall** — texture or paneling appropriate to the venue (tile, brick, wood slat, neon-trimmed panel for the Diner, truck-side corrugated metal for the Food Truck), not a flat gradient rectangle.
- 2 **Built-in furniture/equipment band** — shelving, a menu board, hanging equipment, a pass-through window — anchored to the wall as part of the architecture, sized and positioned so it reads as built, not pinned on top.
- 3 **Light layer** — keep the warm radial wash from the string lights (it works), but consider a secondary light source per venue (an open kitchen glow, a neon sign spill for the Diner, string-light color matching the venue accent) so the lighting is bespoke, not one wash recolored seven times.
- 4 **Counter** — give it real thickness/depth (a front face + a top edge highlight, not a color band), and let it carry venue-appropriate texture (tile front for Sushi, weathered metal for the Food Truck).
- 5 **Floor** — a material appropriate to the room (checkerboard tile for the Diner, polished concrete for the Food Truck's pavement, warm wood for Pizza Piazza) rather than a flat gradient block; the current hard seam where floor meets wall needs a real transition (a baseboard, a shadow gradient with more falloff, or both).

6.3 Ambient life

- Slow ambient motion appropriate to the venue: steam wisps over a hot station, a flickering neon accent on the Diner sign, a gentle string-light sway. Cheap, looping, and each one individually gated behind reduced-motion (see §8).
- Consider a subtle time-of-day tint keyed to the existing Happy Hour window (18:00–20:00 local, already a live game concept — see `ActivePlay.happyHourStartHour` in `Combo.swift`) so the room itself, not just a HUD multiplier, reflects that a Happy Hour is active. Optional, but ties a purely visual change to something the game already tracks.

6.4 The seven rooms, one line of identity each

Use these as a starting point for what makes each room specific — the design pass should feel free to go further, this is a floor, not a ceiling:

- **Burger Shack** — the tutorial's starting room: diner-red vinyl, a classic string-light patio feel, unpretentious and warm.
- **Sushi Bar** — dark wood, a visible bar-top counter, paper lantern lighting instead of bulb string lights.
- **Pizza Piazza** — warm brick oven glow as a secondary light source, checkered accents, a hanging pizza-peel or ingredient rail.

- **Taco Fiesta** — papel-picado-style bunting instead of a plain string, bright saturated tile.
- **Dessert Dream** — pastel palette already distinct; lean into a display-case front on the counter and a softer, glowing light quality.
- **Midnight Diner** — already the night/neon palette; this is the room where a neon sign flicker and a checkerboard floor earn the most.
- **Food Truck Rally** — the odd one out structurally (it's a truck, not a room) — consider a serving-window frame with the truck's interior visible behind the counter and an outdoor/string-lights-on-a-lot backdrop instead of a wall.

6.5 Palette continuity — do not discard these values

The seven-venue hex palette below is not just backdrop color — station cards, the HUD accent, and the Venue Select sheet already key off VenuePaLETTE per venue. The redesign must **keep these exact hues as the identity anchor** for each room (adding tints/shades/textures derived from them is expected and encouraged; replacing the hue family for a venue is not, since it would desync the backdrop from UI chrome elsewhere in the app that isn't part of this brief).

Venue	Wall	Floor	Counter	Accent / glow	Sign plate
Burger Shack		 #D9BE96	 #E4453A	 #F5C242	 #FFE9A8
Sushi Bar		 #C9AE86	 #3F6B5C	 #F4A9A0	 #F6E7C9
Pizza Piazza		 #CBB59A	 #C4462F	 #F0C24B	 #FFE6B8
Taco Fiesta		 #E0C08A	 #E07A3C	 #F5D547	 #FFF0C2
Dessert Dream		 #E8D3C4	 #E88AA8	 #9BD4C8	 #FFE7F0
Midnight Diner		 #C9C2B8	 #5B8BD9	 #F26D9C	 #D8E6FF
Food Truck Rally		 #B8B0A4	 #E07A3C	 #5BD6E8	 #FFEFD1

7. The Golden Customer & VIP Critic

Mechanically: a golden/VIP customer has a 5% base chance to appear per queue rotation once off a 90s cooldown (`ActivePlay.goldenBaseChance`, `goldenCooldown`, `Combo.swift`), pays out a tip scaled to current income, and has a further 5% chance of being the VIP Critic — a $\times 10$ jackpot version (`criticChance`, `criticMultiplier`). This is the single highest-anticipation random moment in the core loop, and today it's visually a crown stuck on the standard figure.

Give it a distinct silhouette treatment, not just an accessory: a genuinely different outfit tier (not one drawn from the same shirt-color array), a glow/aura consistent with the Legendary rarity treatment from §5.4, and a visibly different presentation for the Critic tier specifically versus a regular Golden Customer — right now there's no visual distinction between the two at all, so a $\times 10$ jackpot and a normal tip look identical until the number resolves.

8. Motion, Performance & Accessibility

- The game engine ticks at 20Hz with `TimelineView` interpolation on top for smooth motion between ticks. Any new ambient animation (idle bob, steam, light flicker, rarity shimmer) must be driven the same way — cheap per-frame math in a `Canvas` or `TimelineView`, never a per-frame allocation, and nothing animating while its view is off-screen.
- Every ambient/juice animation needs a static fallback gated on `@Environment(\.accessibilityReduceMotion)` — this is an existing, tested pattern in the codebase (see the prior visual-refresh work); don't introduce a new animation that skips it.
- Dark-theme-only: the app forces dark mode everywhere. Nothing in the new character or venue art may assume a light background will ever be visible behind or around it.
- Don't regress the existing accessibility-label pass on any view this touches (`VenueStageView`, station cards, Collection sheet) — labels and contrast ratios survive the restyle exactly as they did in the prior refresh.

9. File Map

What exists today, and what happens to each file in this brief. This is the actual current file layout — use it as the starting point for implementation, not as a rename target; splitting further (e.g. one file per venue) is fine if it keeps the result maintainable.

File	Owns today	Fate in this brief
<code>Sources/UI/Art/CustomerSprite.swift</code>	Customer/staff figure, hairstyles, outfits, <code>ManagerRarityFrame</code>	Rebuilt -- new figure, kept as the seeded-variation entry point
<code>Sources/UI/Art/VenueProps.swift</code>	Per-theme wall clutter (signs, shelves, equipment icons)	Rebuilt -- becomes the per-venue scene, not a prop overlay

File	Owns today	Fate in this brief
Sources/UI/VenueStageView.swift	Composites wall + props + floor + sign + queue + vignette	Restructured to host real depth layers (\$5.2)
Sources/UI/Theme.swift (VenuePalette)	The 7 venues' wall/floor/counter/accent/sign hex values	Extended, not replaced -- see §6
Sources/UI/Art/GoldenCustomerView (in ActivePlayViews.swift)	The VIP/crowned-customer tap target	Restyled to read as a distinct character, not a tinted regular
Sources/UI/Art/Icons.swift, FoodSprite.swift, CoinBurst.swift	HUD glyphs, food icons, payout/confetti FX	OUT OF SCOPE -- do not touch (see §2)

10. Process & Acceptance Criteria

10.1 How this codebase verifies art changes

This project has no visual regression tooling beyond eyes-on-screenshots — that's the actual process, not a stopgap, and it's how every prior art pass (including the one this brief supersedes) was verified. Follow it:

- 1 Build and run in the iOS Simulator after every meaningful change (`xcodebuild ... -destination 'platform=iOS Simulator,name=iPhone 17 Pro Max'`) and again on an iPad simulator — the stage and station-card figures render at very different sizes across the two, and a rig that only looks right on one is not done.
- 2 Screenshot before making a change and after, and compare side-by-side — never batch several unverified changes together.
- 3 Seed a save with a built-out board (several owned/staffed stations, a visible customer queue, at least one manager of each rarity in the Collection sheet) before screenshotting — a fresh empty save shows none of this art.
- 4 Sweep one venue (or one character element) at a time end-to-end rather than changing all seven venues' wall texture, then all seven floors, etc. — easier to review, easier to revert one room if it doesn't land.

10.2 Definition of done

- All seven venues distinguishable from the backdrop alone, no sign/HUD visible.
- Character figure reads as a person (neck, shoulder taper, hands) at both station-badge scale and Collection-portrait scale.
- A six-person queue reads as six different people, not six recolors.
- Golden Customer and VIP Critic are each visually distinct from a regular staff figure and from each other.
- Four rarity tiers are distinguishable at a glance, not just by reading the ring color.
- Full existing test suite still green (this is art-only, but a build break is a build break) — `xcodebuild test` across the FableTests target.
- No new bundled image assets anywhere in the diff.

Open question for the design pass, not pre-decided here: whether the rebuilt character rig should be a genuinely new proportion system or a deepened version of the current one. This brief argues for new proportions (§5.2) because the current silhouette is the specific thing called out as dated — but if early exploration shows the existing proportions can carry the added anatomy and variation depth this brief asks for, that's a legitimate outcome too. Bring both to a checkpoint before committing to seven venues' worth of matching work.